I had learnt to respect and regard [highly] the United Nations right from my school days. We observed UN days in school and college. We read the Charter with great reverence. We used to have mock sessions. And, of course, we were awestruck by the General Assembly and the Security Council. The United Nations, for all of us, is the symbol of a 'moral capital', serving the Charter and the principles. I used to visit the United Nations as a tourist, sit on the India seat and get myself photographed. Working in it was never even considered, because, for me it was a far away, different, mysterious and beyond-reach world of foreign affairs and diplomacy. But the way my boss, a French national, identified me was human plus divine design. And I will remain grateful to him for this lifelong learning.

Our United Nations is the one and only 'mother' destination for world peace and harmony. It is the only home of all nations, poor or rich, big or small. The United Nations owes to the billions to remain the most credible and visible space for all. All that it does concerns the most vulnerable, for whom there is none else. And this is what I have seen firsthand – which for me has been a rare privilege.

But for many of us, our flagship, the 'mother', the UN itself, is [facing] stormy weather. The Blue Flag and the Blue Helmet [are] weakening sanctuaries. Increasingly, the United Nations and its personnel are being targeted on various counts. On the other hand, there is a growing trend towards marginalization of the world body, thereby rocking its very foundation.

One of the constant challenges before the United Nations is its dependence on external financial support, along with erosion of credibility. The gigantic ones that persist are ones of poverty and disease. If that was not enough, there is the vulnerability of human security – most of the time aggravated by malgovernance.

How does the 'world body' address this? We the workers who are entrusted with the responsibility of peace keeping are duty-bound to rise above our insecurities and geographies and make our 'careers as causes' for protecting and promoting the core values of the United Nations, along with ensuring peace and development for the weak and uprooted. While I take a bow, I now return to my 'homework' that I did leave behind, incomplete, besides the responsibility I have towards my ageing father. I will be glad to be of any service in Delhi. I am only three digits away. Just call 100 – the police control room will know my whereabouts.

I share with you a belief I try to practise:

Change is the law. Growth is optional. Choose wisely …

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Kiran had clearly chosen not to extend her stay in New York beyond two years, essentially for two reasons: she had to take care of her ageing father and she was also keen to return to her own Delhi Police. But on her return to India, instead of her international experience being appreciated, valued and put to good use, it became a source of vicious envy. All possible manipulations were put in place to keep her out. She faced a ganging up of her adversaries, who were hell-bent on hurting her. First, by blocking her promotion and then by trying to puncture her integrity. The latter mischief got exposed when one of the reporters of a widely read national daily, which had been fed with the story, rang her up to crosscheck before publishing the item the following morning. Kiran asked him to come home later for her version as she was about to board a plane. He had to perforce hold back the news report. The following morning when the reporter was shown all the audit reports of the story planted he felt 'used'. He refused to file the story. He subsequently lost his job. Such was the influence of the 'planter'.